

Christopher Columbus

Born in Genoa, Christopher Columbus became a business agent for several prominent Genoese families and undertook trading voyages in Europe and along the African coast.

Columbus followed his voyage to America with a second in 1493, during which he explored the Lesser and Greater

Antilles, and set up a colony at La Isabela in what is now the Dominican Republic. His third voyage (1498–1500) took him to the Caribbean island of Hispaniola and on to Trinidad, where he found the coast of South America and guessed, from the size of the Orinoco River, that he had found a huge land mass. During this time, settlers complained to the Crown about the way he ran his Caribbean

colony, and he was dismissed as governor.

On his last voyage (1502–1504) he sailed along the Central American coast, hoping to find a strait to the Indian Ocean. He returned to Spain in poor health and an increasingly disturbed state of mind, feeling he had not received the recognition and benefits he had been promised. Columbus died in 1506.

10 percent of any revenues they yielded, Columbus set sail westward in 1492. He called at Gran Canaria before sailing west, sighting land five weeks later. In early 1493 he returned to Europe with two ships, the third having been wrecked off the coast of present-day Haiti, and was duly appointed Governor of the Indies.

Columbus's second expedition was organized just a few months later. This involved 17 ships loaded with some 1,200 people who would found Spanish colonies in the Caribbean. As well as farmers and soldiers, the colonists included priests, who were specifically charged with converting local people to Christianity. Religious conversion became a key part of European colonization, illustrating the colonist's ambition to impose their own culture and exert control over newly colonized peoples.

Columbus's achievement in 1492 is often described as the European "discovery" of America. This is a problematic claim not only because Columbus thought he had reached Asia, but also because Vikings from Scandinavia had reached North America some 500 years earlier—archaeological remains at L'Anse aux Meadows in Newfoundland reveal that they even settled there. However, the Viking settlement was not long-lived, and was unknown to Columbus and his contemporaries.

Nevertheless, Columbus's 1492 journey did inaugurate a lasting contact between the Americas and Europe. The pitiless destruction he and his men wrought upon the indigenous peoples of the West Indies, whom he encountered when he first arrived in the Americas, also began a process of decimation of Native American populations that would continue for a century. ■

